

Cover story **CRICKET**

audience. But the IPL has been left looking not like a 21st Century business but a slice of old-style Indian *dhandha*. Excessively centralised, dangerously unregulated, with much questionable practice.

The IPL's troubles today are mostly self-inflicted and inflicted, many believe, by the League's face and voice, its controversial Commissioner Lalit Modi. The run-in with the Government could have been averted with a little advance-planning and old-world diplomacy, the ugly TV rights dispute with a little bit more respect for the corporate contract. Twenty-six days before Season 2 was to begin, the IPL had neither a venue nor an official broadcaster: the game's first privately owned professional T-20 league was looking like an amateur production.

After hitting a rich vein of gold last year, the IPL suddenly has little choice in Season 2 but to prospect through unknown territory. South Africa loves T-20, knows how to put up a T-20 event (in the 2007 World T-20 scoreboards shot off fireworks with every six). But it will have to pull in the crowds night after night across six venues for six weeks to watch an Indian cricket event during what will soon be rugby season.

The IPL needs crowds to make the TV look good. More than one player has said they would miss the buzz of playing in front of India's noisy, partisan thousands. If the size of the TV audience drove the IPL's success, crammed stands and the roar of the crowd gave producers the backdrop needed to amp up the event. Television, the backbone of IPL earnings, feeds off atmospherics. How does a commentator holler "...and the crowd goes wild", if there is no crowd to show going wild? What comes first, the optics or the eyeballs? Analysts expect ratings to dip by 15 per cent with an offshore IPL which would instantly impact ad demand. On the ground, local sponsors of IPL teams are now clutching at air. At the one time they can maximise their investment with promotions and player-outreach, the players will have relocated to an alien city.

Franchise owners can do little but try to maximise their chance to reach a wider audience. According to Amrit Mathur, coo, Delhi Daredevils, "Logically, every franchise would try to extend their fan base beyond their catchment area after a few years. Ready or not, that process has been fast-tracked. We have to create opportunity out of adversity."

The IPL was built on the American model of private ownership of sports teams and the manufacturing of 'fan loyalty', rather than evolving the European soccer model of support. Television professionals believe the IPL's funda-



IPL TEAM OWNERS WITH LALIT MODI: WILL THE SMILES LAST?



“The cost of shifting IPL to another country is prohibitive. We are not looking at the losses but we will not make any money this year.”

LALIT MODI,
IPL Commissioner

mentals need more work. The League's benchmarks and models have always been global, big-ticket, multi-million dollar acronyms: EPL, NBA, NFL, F1. Each one is the pinnacle of their professionalised sport, smoothly organised, expertly televised and slickly marketed.

After securing loyal home bases, their next logical move is overseas to 'developmental' markets. Everywhere they go, though, says Peter Hutton, chief operating officer of Taj TV which owns Ten Sports, "they insist on packed stadia and the same quality of experience as 'back home'. For the IPL to attempt such quality with virtually no preparation is a huge gamble." Good events and good TV, he says, are based on detailed planning. But for the IPL that has been replaced with the faith that "the format is so strong that, of course, everything will work".

The IPL's dramatic offshore departure is rooted in its basic strength as a novel product, but also contains the seeds of its economic uncertainty. Anything less than enthusiastic appreciation by India will adversely impact valuations and future seasons. If it translates well in an alien environment, though, the IPL could turn into a juggernaut that world cricket itself will find tough to halt.